

PITTSBURGH TRIBUNE-REVIEW

Appreciate beauty and wonder of Great Allegheny Passage trail

By Paul g. Wiegman
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Last month, I wrote that although the Great Allegheny Passage is well known as a cycling trail, I view it in a different light. For me, it's one LONG nature trail.

I started at the Point in Pittsburgh and sketched some natural history highlights of the Passage along the way.

Because the trail is so long (more than 150 miles) and there is so much to see, I only got as far as Ohiopyle. Here's a look at some of the rest of the Great Allegheny Passage's natural history.

Six miles south of Ohiopyle, the trail comes out of the woods and into a large meadow that was once a farm. If you pay careful attention you'll recognize this place by the narrow gas pipeline clearing that leads off to the west. This is the water gap of the Yough River through Laurel Ridge -- the deepest water gap in Pennsylvania. The summit of Laurel Ridge is 1,200 feet higher than the trail. Compare that to the famous "Grand Canyon of Pennsylvania" at Wellsboro, which is a mere 800 feet deep.

Just a mile or two further south is a limestone outcrop, Finnegan's Ledges. Spring wildflowers are bountiful here with tufts of wild columbine growing right out of the rock face. The columbine attests to the alkaline nature of the rock, since it is a plant which grows only in "sweet," limey, non-acid soils.

At Confluence, the Passage leaves the Youghiogheny River and follows the Casselman River. At an overlook of the meeting of these two rivers, natural history gives way to human history. On May 21, 1754, George Washington camped on the point of land between the rivers while searching for a route from tidewater on Chesapeake Bay to the forks of the Ohio. The trip was part military and part speculation. Col. Washington was looking to oust the French from the Forks of the Ohio. Businessman Washington was looking for a route for goods to flow from the East Coast to the new American wilderness.

Near Harnedsville, around Mile 58, is another great location for spring wildflowers. Trillium, yellow trout lily, Dutchman's breeches, violets and more are abundant here in April and May. Late summer brings the mountain bugbane, a rare plant of the Alleghenies, into bloom.

This stretch of trail also illustrates the changing nature of the landscape.

Alongside the Passage is a fresh landslide scar and a huge angular boulder almost jutting onto the trail. This garage-sized chunk of rock broke loose from a

ledge above and tumbled down the slope in the spring of 2007. It's a reminder that these rivers are constantly cutting their valleys deeper and deeper, and the adjacent slopes are eroding into the rivers. Eventually all the landscape we see will be reduced to monotonous flatness. Don't worry. It's taken a very, very, very long time to carve today's terrain, and it will take an equally long time before it is all flat.

South of Fort Hill, the Casselman River loops around the Pinkerton Horn. The Horn is a huge bend in the Casselman River where the water encountered a very hard ledge of rock and was forced to take a circuitous route.

The old railroad path crosses the Pinkerton High Bridge with the river far below. The views from this location are exceptional, especially in the fall. After crossing the High Bridge directly ahead is the Pinkerton Tunnel and just beyond that the Pinkerton Low Bridge. The straight line distance is a couple of hundred feet.

However, after rock-falls in the tunnel, it was closed. The Passage then was routed to follow the path of the river for 1.3 miles around the Horn, ending up at the other end of the closed tunnel and the Pinkerton Low Bridge. The river at the Low Bridge is less than 20 feet below deck. When compared to the High Bridge, you get a graphic illustration of the steep fall of the rivers in this region.

At Meyersdale, the Passage leaves the Casselman River and follows the smaller Flaugherty Creek. The higher up the watershed, the smaller the streams and, from Meyersdale the eight miles to Deal bring you to the top of all watersheds.

Just southeast of Deal is the Eastern Continental Divide.

A low ridge divides the run-off of the Mississippi watershed from that of the Potomac watershed. Spill part of your water bottle on one side of the divide and it will flow to the Gulf of Mexico and a spill on the other side will reach the Chesapeake Bay.

For cyclists, it's less about water and more about hills. Either direction from here is all downhill.

Just beyond the southeast portal of the Big Savage Tunnel is a vista of the edge of what geographers call the Ridge and Valley Province. It's part of the Appalachian Mountains, some of the oldest mountains in the world. Standing on the flank of Big Savage Mountain you see a straight, long, narrow clearing cutting across the mountains and into the valleys. It is a clearing for a gas pipeline, but more importantly, it is almost exactly on the border between Pennsylvania and Maryland -- the Mason-Dixon line.

The Passage from Big Savage Mountain into Cumberland, Md., is a long, easy downhill ride. The railroad needed a steady grade, so there are numerous narrow cuts into spurs of the mountain. Here the underlaying geology is opened like an ancient book with page on page of layered rock.

When cutting into a layer of limestone on the western slope of Wills Mountain, a

sinkhole cave was exposed. Cumberland Bone Cave is closed to public use but you can stop and walk to the fence and see what was once the bottom of the sinkhole. Scientists from the Smithsonian Institution carefully excavated accumulated debris at the bottom of the pit when it was first found in 1912.

They found the remains of thousands of animals in the mix, some as small as snails and insects to others as large as saber-tooth cats and extinct elephants. The pit was a trap for creatures that happened to stumble into the opening. However, when opened, it was one of the finest records of eastern North America dating from 1.8 million to 10,000 years ago.

The Ice Age mammal exhibit at the Smithsonian Institution National Museum of Natural History in Washington, D.C., contains skeletons of a cave bear and extinct wolverine from Bone Cave.

From Pittsburgh to Cumberland, from tiny wildflowers to towering tulip poplars, from extinct saber-tooth cats to scurrying chipmunks, from ancient rocks to new landslides, the Great Allegheny Passage covers them all. It's pretty clear why it can be called one LONG nature trail.

Paul g. Wiegman is a freelance writer, photographer and naturalist born and raised in western Pennsylvania. Write to him c/o Pittsburgh Tribune-Review, 503 Martindale St., Pittsburgh, PA 15212; or e-mail him at pgwphotography@gmail.com

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